Emergency

By Daniel Beaty

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

Suggested Roles: ***Actor*** *– Reporter 1, Slave-ologist, Ronald, Vendor, Rodney*
Actress *– Clarissa, Bessie, Reporter 2, Black Female Scholar*

REPORTER 1: **(Pg 13)** We are live at Liberty Island with this breaking news report. A slave ship has just risen out of the Hudson River in front of the Statue of Liberty. That's right, you heard me. A slave ship has just risen out of the Hudson River in front of the Statue of Liberty. Slave-ologists are busy trying to figure it out. Let's get some live on the spot feedback from the crowd gathering here at Liberty Island.

CLARISSA: **(Pg 14)** I mean, I ain't never really thought about slavery before this slave ship . . . They ain't teach us nothin' about it in school. Naw, they ain't teach us about Africa or nothing. Yeh, okay, they taught us about Egypt. The pyramids and stuff, right? Yeh, but nothing about ***Africa***. *(listens to a voice from the crowd)* Egypt is in Africa? Them people was black?!

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR: *A growing throng of African Americans flood the shores near the Statue of Liberty. Beyond rational explanation, the invisible past has materialized and it quickly become an . . . Emergency by Daniel Beaty.*

BESSIE: **(Pg 13)** *(a seventy something soulful southern grandmother)* When I first saw the slave ship, I was in stunned silence. Then I started to pray, "Thank

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you Jesus! Hallelujah! Thank you for not forgetting about your people. Thank you for this sign to help us remember who we are."

RONALD: **(Pg 14)** *(a forty something high class colored man)* It's . . . it's . . . appalling! It's a setback. There are black people succeeding in every field-tennis, golf, we even run for president. This is the last thing we need.

REPORTER 2: **(Pg 24)** Tensions are high and escalating here at Liberty Island. Hundreds of people are arriving with suitcases, old trunks, even trash bags full of clothes attempting to board the ship. Oprah is calling this slave ship a "full circle "ah ha" moment." Liberty is in a state of emergency.

RONALD: **(Pg 14-15)** I work in corporate America and one of my colleagues just came into my office in tears after hearing the news on the radio and she tells me she has papers that prove her great great grandparents owned slaves and she wants to apologize. And I said, "Why are you apologizing to me, Cathy? It was your great great grandparents." And she's hysterical, and so I say, "Look at me, Cathy. You've been to my home, our children play together. Cathy, I'm your boss!"

BIACK FEMALE SCHOLAR: *(a fifty-something; angry sistah with an education)* This slave ship is proof that slavery is not history, its reality. I write books on Post Traumatic Slave Syndrome - how slavery still impacts the minds and hearts of black people today. Look at these people's faces. This is exactly why most of us never watch those PBS specials or talk about slavery with our children. We don't know what to do with the anger.

VENDOR: **(Pg 22)** Yo! Check it! Slave ship buttons! Yo' ma, check it, I got yo' slave' ship buttons!

BLACK FEMALE SCHOLAR: **(Pg 23)** *(distracted for a moment by the vendor then returning to her speech)* It's not about the few us that make it; it's what slavery has

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done to the psyche of the masses. Why do you think there are more black people in jail and poor than any other group? Because we're inferior? No, the ghetto is a modern-day plantation.

RONALD: **(Pg 39)** Slavery ended two hundred years ago. We need to get over it. It's been forty years since the Civil Rights Movement. It's time to move on people. This place is out of control.

BLACK FEMALE SCHOLAR: **(Pg 23)** Don't get it twisted; you can have a six-figure income, a PhD, and still be a slave. But it's never too late to redeem the past, is it?

REPORTER 1: **(Pg 26)** Reporting live from Liberty Island where the crowds have gotten out of control. Some people are running around screaming, speaking in unknown tongues as if possessed and dancing what appears to be ancient African dance. *(Actress does just that: screams, speaks in an unknown tongue and dances an ancient African dance)*

RONALD: **(Pg 39-40)** *(Distracted by the dancing, but then returns to his speech)* Not all white Americans owned slaves. Many fought to free them. Affirmative action was reparations enough. I'm not an Uncle Tom. I'm not a sellout. I'm just tired of black people asking for a handout. I don't need to go back to Africa. I can reconnect . . . to that black man begging money for food *(points to a person in the crowd)*. Reconnect to that black woman prostituting herself to keep a roof over her head. *(points to a person in the crowd).* Reconnect to those black kids in the orphanages who are like four and five-years old living with AIDS who nobody wants to adopt because they're sick. Yes, they are the product of this slave ship, but nobody's going to help us if we don't start helping ourselves! *(pause)* We are here now. We have arrived.

REPORTER 2: **(Pg 26)** We are speaking now with a slave-ologist. You are from

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Ghana, West Africa, correct?

SLAVE-OLOGIST: *(forty-something West African man)* Yes, I am. We have identified the slave ship as one of the many dispatched from the Cape Coast Slave Dungeons of Ghana, West Africa. We call this slave ship Remembrance. **(Pg 37-38)** *(To the crowd gathered around)* As a slave-ologist, slave dungeons are my specialty. And with this slave ship, I feel compelled to tell you what I know. I will take you on a tour as if you were standing with me in Ghana, West Africa. *(Actress joins the tour and reacts silently to the Slave-Ologist)* The slave dungeons you are about to see are the largest facility where the Africans were kept during the Transatlantic Slave Trade. As our tour begins, we ask that you leave your rage and pain at the entrance gate because there is enough inside. Thank you and please follow me. *(As he turns upstage, his hands cross violently above his head as if chained. Enraged, he speaks the following words of resistance to an imaginary guard.)* ***Olokikijulu amanla owetu! Olokikijulu amanla owetu!*** *(To crowd)* We have now entered the Slave Dungeons where the Africans were kept. Here, they defecated on the same floor where they slept and ate. This is where the Africans were brought before they boarded slave ships like Remembrance for the passage to America . . .

TRANSITION

ACTRESS: *But then, just as mysteriously as The Remembrance appeared, the great slave ship sank.*

ACTOR: *Leaving many to wonder if it was real, or just a figment of their collective consciousness.*

REPORTER 2: **(Pg 49-51)** Remembrance has disappeared. Moments ago the slave ship Remembrance began to sink back into the Hudson River. Divers were immediately dispatched into the water and all they see is an

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endless stretch of skeletons, human bones, and the chains are gone. And what's even more bizarre is that while Remembrance has disappeared from the vision of most of us here at Liberty Island others are insisting that they can still see it floating right here in front of the Statue of Liberty. *(The Reporter fades from the scene, leaving Rodney alone on stage)*

RODNEY: *(A performance poet)* The pain I feel and the pain I see
It's a pain particular to being black in this country,
And it's a pain beyond race, class, sex, or any other label of identity-
We are all afraid, all confused, all connected ... all Free
As Free as we choose to be
I tell the story for that man begging money for food,
For that child living with **AIDS**,
Our bones, our bones, our bones they breathe:
In this world we may be bound but our spirits are free
And our bones, our bones, our bones they breathe:
We can overcome if we change the way we see
See ourselves, see our past, see our possibility
Our bones, our bones, our bones they breathe:
We are all family!
We must not die!
We must not sleep!
We must wake up!
Wake up and DREAM!

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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